

An influential twist to political PR

Officials turn to social media creators to shape news, promote positions

By Anjali Huynh and Samantha J. Gross
GLOBE STAFF

Atop the State House steps, a select few gathered with Governor Maura Healey and Santa Claus for the annual December tree-lighting ceremony.

Below them, members of the press, the public, and those driving down Beacon Street gazed up at the colossal tree through a wrought iron

fence. But looking on from an area restricted to the public and steps from Healey, was a different crowd, phones in hand: the influencers.

The access Healey afforded to Kate Weiser, creator of the megapopular “Bucket List Boston,” travel influencer Sally Nguyen, and a host of other social media personalities embodied Massachusetts politicians’ growing embrace of friendly social media stars to boost their

reach beyond traditional press.

Healey is offering creators one-on-one interviews, inviting them to events, and promoting their social media accounts on her own. An influencer now sits on a city of Boston nightlife committee. The state’s attorney general appeared on another’s podcast.

In Massachusetts and beyond, politicians have increasingly turned to people with armies of followers to promote events, boost policies, or build coalitions in election years. That shift has raised questions about how transparent politicians

and the influencers they work with should be as they knit their social feeds together.

“Democrats have been playing catch-up — right-wing influencers are so embedded into the political system that they’re being appointed to [high-level] positions,” said Carly Carioli, of Boston-based marketing agency, Gupta Media. “We’re seeing the rise of politicians who are acting like creators to take advantage of ways that the platforms we all watch rank and distribute content.”

“Creators” was a buzzword of the

INFLUENCERS, Page A10

Lifelines to hospitals rock health networks

Fiscal chaos follows deals for former Steward sites

By Jessica Bartlett
GLOBE STAFF

It’s like buying the fixer-upper from hell.

The systems acquiring the former Steward Health Care hospitals knew they were walking into a tough situation, after years of Steward’s neglect, deterioration, and negative headlines around the bankrupt company. But few expected the takeovers to be this hard.

By the time Boston Medical Center took over the former St. Elizabeth’s Hospital in Brighton and Good Samaritan Medical Center in Brockton in October 2024, both hospitals had lost a steady flow of patients. They also needed millions in improvements, from replacing an old medical record system that struggled to bill for services to fixing broken elevators.

“The financial performance was an order of magnitude worse — for a number of reasons — than we or anyone had expected,” said Dr. Alastair Bell, chief executive of Boston Medical Center Health System.

One year into new ownership, the former Steward hospitals are a major drag on the finances of their new owners, records show. For some, it is costing them much more to operate the facilities than Steward had prepared them for, while others were surprised by the sheer scale of the upgrades. Meanwhile revenues from patients were much lower than forecast.

STEWARD, Page A7

State ramps up hiring, pay for bar advocates

Action eases court backlog for indigent defendants

By Sean Cotter
GLOBE STAFF

Last summer, hundreds of court-appointed attorneys who represent the state’s poorest defendants held a work stoppage that nearly ground the state’s justice system to a halt. Thousands of criminal defendants had no access to lawyers, leading judges to dismiss thousands of cases and release dozens of jailed defendants in a crisis that imperiled both the defendants’ constitutional rights and public safety.

Now, any indigent criminal defendant who needs access to a lawyer can quickly get one. The state’s efforts to address the shortage of lawyers, known as bar advocates, appear to have worked — at least for the moment.

Although many of the private attorneys continue their work stoppage as they seek higher pay rates, the state has hired more staff lawyers and used financial incentives to persuade enough private lawyers back to work to cut a backlog of cases that at one point reached into the thousands. It’s been months since Suffolk and Middlesex judges have held hearings to release defendants or dis-

LAWYERS, Page A4



ELSA/GETTY IMAGES

For the first time since their storied run in 1980, the US men’s Olympic hockey team are gold medalists. The team beat archrival Canada in sudden death overtime, 2-1, on a goal by Jack Hughes in Milan Sunday. **C1.**



A snow of force

Monday: Blizzard, high winds. High 31-36, low 22-27.

Tuesday: Sunny, cold at night. High 31-36, low 14-19.

Sunrise: 6:29. Sunset: 5:26.

Weather and comics, **D4-5.**
Obituaries, **C9.**

An armed man was shot to death by law enforcement, including Secret Service agents, near President Trump’s Mar-a-Lago resort in Florida. **A2.**

One of Mexico’s most notorious criminal leaders, Nemesio Oseguera Cervantes, was killed by Mexican forces. **A3.**

Scientists look to states to help fund their research as federal commitment dwindles. **D1.**

The Supreme Court ruling tossing out President Trump’s tariffs generated frustration and confusion among those trade allies that had forged agreements with Trump. **A3.**

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Healey deploys National Guard troops as potentially historic nor’easter lands

Blizzard could ‘make you forget about those last ones’

By Sarah Rahal
GLOBE STAFF
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GLOBE CORRESPONDENT

Hours before what’s expected to be the worst of the storms in New England this winter, Governor Maura Healey declared a state of emergency, and local officials urgently enacted safety measures, warning that venturing out could be “potentially life-threatening.”

Healey activated emergency operations centers Sunday and deployed 200 members of the Massachusetts

National Guard to bolster response efforts. The governor ordered all non-essential state employees to work from home Monday and urged private employers to do the same.

“Snowfall rates are going to be high ... We expect to see whiteout conditions and near-zero visibility,” Healey said. “This is going to be wetter, heavier snow, and we expect to see downed power lines.”

She also asked residents to stay off the roads. “If you lose power, call 211 to find the closest warming center,” she said.

In Boston, Mayor Michelle Wu ordered widespread closures for Monday, including City Hall, Boston Public Schools, municipal buildings, libraries, and community centers.

At Boston Logan International Airport, nearly 400 flights were canceled by Sunday evening as airlines braced for the shutdown of travel. MassDOT’s highway administrator said 3,000 pieces of snow equipment and plenty of salt were ready to deploy statewide.

Standing with top emergency

STORM, Page A7

Patrons, owner rally to try to save vintage diner

Buddy’s was a vibrant place in neighborhood in Somerville. Then a plumbing disaster hit.

By Spencer Buell
GLOBE STAFF

SOMERVILLE — Through the windows of Buddy’s Diner, the old-school 1920s lunch car with the big, friendly red-and-blue sign, you can still catch a glimpse of better days for this local landmark.

Since a plumbing issue forced it to close three years ago, its 19 black vinyl stools have been empty. The flat-top grill, ice cold. The lunch specials, handwritten on paper plates and hung up with clothespins, are fading in the sunlight with no one here to order them.

As one of the region’s last authentic vintage lunch cars, Buddy’s was a time capsule, keeping the neighborhood well

fed with hot platters of hand-cracked eggs and made-to-order bacon on the cheap.

Now it’s a mausoleum. “It just makes me so sad and depressed and angry,” said owner Nicole Bairos. Before this past week, she hadn’t been there in person in months.

Fearing what could be lost forever, neighbors are trying to gin up enough public support, and funding, to keep the endangered landmark alive.

“Niki” to regulars, Bairos bought Buddy’s in 2006 when she was 22 years old, after learning her way around a kitchen at her parents’ Portuguese American fish market on Broadway.

DINER, Page A10



PAT GREENHOUSE/GLOBE STAFF

On Valentine’s Day, supporters wrote love notes on paper plates, which were hung on windows of Buddy’s Diner, with owner Nicole Bairos in between.